SUPPLY RESILIENCE

Securing continuity through disruption

A criticality-led approach to supply resilience

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THE CHALLENGE

Protecting continuity when supply is constrained

A shortage that reached the customer

After the pandemic, component lead times rose sharply and finished-product lead times followed, to many times their normal level.

Limited visibility of supply

Available inventory and next supply dates were often uncertain, which produced surprises late in the chain.

Cost discipline against continuity

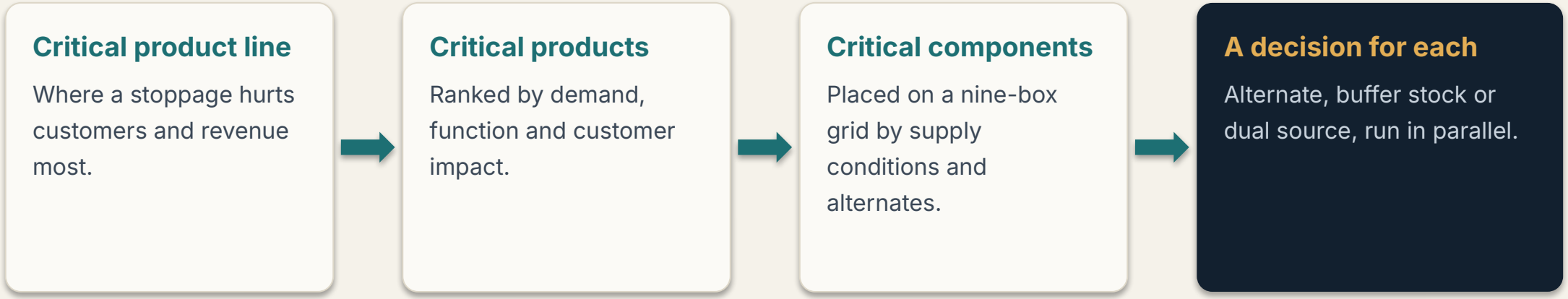
Procurement had to hold cost targets, while the business needed a view of what was critical to keep shipping.

Strained supplier relationships

Some suppliers held back supply over pending payments, and scarce supply had to be prioritised across competing customers.

THE REFRAME

A criticality lens: protect what stops shipments



> The lens added the continuity view alongside cost discipline, and anchored every decision to the product roadmap.

THE PORTFOLIO OF LEVERS

Each lever matched to the risk it removes

Lever	Risk it removes	Strategic intent
Alternates	Long or uncertain lead times	Qualified with R&D and built into the product
Buffer stock	Components with no alternate	Sized on cost, availability, quality and impact
Dual sourcing	Single-source exposure	Suppliers found, samples tested, cost reviewed
Premium purchases	Parts outside normal channels	A business-impact case, with finance approving
Product roadmap	End-of-life and paired products	Replacement timing used to plan supply

No single fix did it. The recovery came from the levers working together.

GOVERNING THE TRADE-OFFS

Decisions at the boundary of cost, supply and customer

Cost against continuity

Premium purchases were recommended from a supply-criticality view, with the business impact set out for each. Finance approved the spend.

Supplier relationships

Supplier visits validated set-up, quality and committed timelines. Payment holds that stopped supply were escalated and cleared with the required approvals.

Customer priority

Weekly reviews with customers, customer-facing teams and sales, then a clear call on priority and clear, communicated delivery dates.

> Every trade-off was made explicit, with an owner, a business case and an approval.

ALIGNING THE ENTERPRISE

Leading across functions through mandate and rhythm

A management mandate gave authority over delivery prioritisation and customer commitments, and the functions involved were bound to involve the role.

There was no team and no reporting line over those functions. Results came from a shared view of the risk, a steady cadence and decisions that were visible to everyone.

Close proximity to the plant kept the picture honest, from regular contact to daily presence.

The operating rhythm

A weekly crisis forum with senior management from finance, procurement, R&D, production and sales

A weekly report: status, new challenges, resolved and pending items, impacted orders and a rolling action list

Challenge of demand projections, and review of production plans and buffer and obsolescence

OUTCOMES

A substantial recovery, honestly read

Lead times

Fell to a fraction of their peak across the product families, led by the most important product.

On-time delivery

Improved materially, reached while the shortage was still under way.

Customer confidence

Customers felt significant relief, and the recovery was regarded across the business as a major achievement.

> Component supply never fully normalised, and the final stretch was paced on purpose, balancing lead time against inventory cost.

LESSONS AND NEXT STEPS

What leaders can take from this

Give continuity an owner

Put the question of what is critical alongside cost discipline, with one accountable view.

Invest in visibility early

Better systems to track the chain and material availability would have reduced the surprises.

Pay for certainty deliberately

A premium is a decision with a business case, not a reflex.

Where I can help

Supply criticality assessment

Which products and components can stop revenue, and what to do about each.

Shortage-recovery governance

A cross-functional forum, a reporting rhythm and clear decision rights.

Resilience design

Alternates, buffer and dual sourcing, tied to the product roadmap.